

LI MA

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

AI/ML researcher with a Ph.D. and experience in recommender systems, graph learning, retrieval-augmented generation, and generative AI. Research published or accepted at NeurIPS, ICLR, KDD, TKDD, and EACL, with industry research internship experience at Ant Group and Alibaba Group and prior full-time backend development experience. Experienced in machine learning experimentation, data analysis, and software development using Python, Java, SQL, and PyTorch.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Case Western Reserve University

Visiting Researcher, Computer Science

Cleveland, OH

06/2026 -- Present

- Conducting research on foundation models, with current interests in causal reasoning and world models.

Michigan State University

Visiting Researcher, Computer Science

East Lansing, MI

08/2023 -- 05/2026

- Evaluated tokenizer designs for generative recommendation and developed a graph-based heuristic method that demonstrated strong empirical performance.
- Co-led the development of Link-MoE, a structure-aware mixture-of-experts framework for graph link prediction; co-first-authored the resulting paper published at NeurIPS 2024.
- Contributed to two RAG-related projects: one on RAG and GraphRAG evaluation and the other on privacy risks; both accepted at KDD 2026.
- Designed an LLM-based multi-agent framework for clinical note assessment and evaluated planner-executor agent systems under adversarial interference; the latter work was published at EACL 2026.

Shanghai Jiao Tong University

Doctoral Researcher

Shanghai, China

09/2019 -- 09/2025

- Conducted doctoral research on graph representation learning and recommender systems, with applications to social recommendation, sequential user modeling, and graph-based route planning.
- Led end-to-end research activities including problem formulation, model development, experimental evaluation, and technical writing.

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

Alibaba Group

Research Intern, Advertising Recommendation Team

Beijing, China

05/2022 -- 01/2023

- Processed live-stream interaction data and engineered features for recommendation modeling.
- Constructed temporal graphs of user-streamer interactions for user-follow prediction and offline analysis.

Ant Group

Research Intern, Graph Platform Team

Hangzhou, China

04/2021 -- 04/2022

- Developed a task-supervised graph structure learning framework with learnable thresholds to remove noisy edges.
- Demonstrated improvements in node classification and link prediction on heterogeneous and low-homophily graph benchmarks; the resulting first-author work was published in ACM TKDD in 2025.

Puxin Hengye Technology Co., Ltd.

Backend Development Engineer, Big Data Innovation Center

Beijing, China

07/2018 -- 08/2019

- Developed and maintained Java backend services and wrote SQL queries for an internal web platform supporting data access.
- Participated in service deployment, logging, and production issue troubleshooting.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming: Python, Java, SQL, C/C++, MATLAB

Machine Learning: PyTorch, PyTorch Geometric, PyTorch Lightning, Scikit-learn, NumPy, Pandas

Methods: Deep Learning, Recommender Systems, Rankings, Generative Recommendation, Graph Neural Networks, Retrieval-Augmented Generation, Large Language Models, Data Analysis, Model Evaluation

Tools: Git, Linux, Jupyter, LaTeX

EDUCATION

Shanghai Jiao Tong University

Ph.D. in Electronic and Information Engineering

Shanghai, China

09/2019 -- 09/2025

Xidian University

M.S. in Computer Science and Technology

Xi'an, China

09/2015 -- 06/2018

Shanxi University

B.E. in Software Engineering

Taiyuan, China

09/2011 -- 07/2015

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS (* indicates equal contribution)

First and Co-first Author Publications

- **Li Ma***, H. Han*, et al. “Mixture of Link Predictors on Graphs.” **NeurIPS**, 2024.
- **Li Ma**, et al. “Building Robust and Trustworthy HGNN Models: A Learnable Threshold Approach for Node Classification.” **ACM TKDD**, 2025.
- **Li Ma**, et al. “ExpoEv: Enhancing Social Recommendation Service with Social Exposure and Feature Evolution.” **ICWS**, 2023.

Selected Co-authored Publications

- H. Han, **Li Ma**, et al. “RAG vs. GraphRAG: A Systematic Evaluation and Key Insights.” **KDD**, 2026.
- Z. Qi, U. Sahu, **Li Ma**, et al. “Benchmarking Knowledge-Extraction Attack and Defense on Retrieval-Augmented Generation.” **KDD**, 2026.
- S. Dong, M. Zhang, P. He, **Li Ma**, et al. “PEAR: Planner-Executor Agent Robustness Benchmark.” **EACL**, 2026.
- B. Chen, Y. Kang, **Li Ma**, et al. “Decoupling User Features for User Cold-Start App Recommendation: Static Attributes versus Behavioral Sequences.” **WSDM**, 2026.
- H. Han, X. Liu, **Li Ma**, et al. “Structural Fairness-aware Active Learning for Graph Neural Networks.” **ICLR**, 2024.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- Teaching Assistant, Data Structures and Algorithms, Shanghai Jiao Tong University: Led recitation sessions, held office hours, and supported an English-taught course with 140+ students.

HONORS AND AWARDS

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| • NeurIPS Scholar Award | 2024 |
| • China Undergraduate Mathematical Contest in Modeling, Top 5.6% | 2013 |
| • China Graduate Mathematical Contest in Modeling, Top 35% | 2020 |

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

- Reviewer for NeurIPS, KDD, WWW, CIKM, ICDM, ICWS, TKDE, and TKDD.